

West Bengal- Resolve to succeed

It is not easy to shed an image that has been built over years and the West Bengal chief minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya has been trying to do just that – trying to showcase West Bengal as an industry friendly state.

The state government also showed patience and resolve in regard to the Tata Motor's Nano project in Singur and despite a lot of adversities, the project is now on course. With talks with the opposition leader Miss Mamata Banerjee being fruitful, the hopes of the dream car Nano rolling out of the Singur plant remains high.

West Bengal has been able to shrug off some of the negative image and top industrialists of India, and some from abroad, have shown interest in building up industry and facilities here.

The presence of an educated and skilled workforce is now being seen as an asset and the government's efforts are positive.

Mr. Bhattacharya has been trying to change the face of West Bengal, being vocal against bandhs and problems stemming from labour unrests and the state is gearing up for sunny days ahead.

The Tata's Nano factory at Singur and the proposed chemical hub at Nayachar are examples of such developments. The developments in the industrial sector will naturally improve employment opportunities and in turn result in a better quality of life.

The West Bengal Industrial Development Corporation is the guiding body responsible for the development, growth, facilitation and trouble shooting of industry, investment and infrastructure in West Bengal. It also has a role as a financial institute for large and medium scale sectors.

Formed in 1967, WBIDC has established Growth Centres with basic industrial and social infrastructure facilities across the state.

The Corporation is actively engaged in catalysing investment through promotion/marketing of West Bengal as an investment destination, assisting in the implementation of projects through its 'Single Window Facility' called the 'State Investment Facilitation Centre' (SIFC).

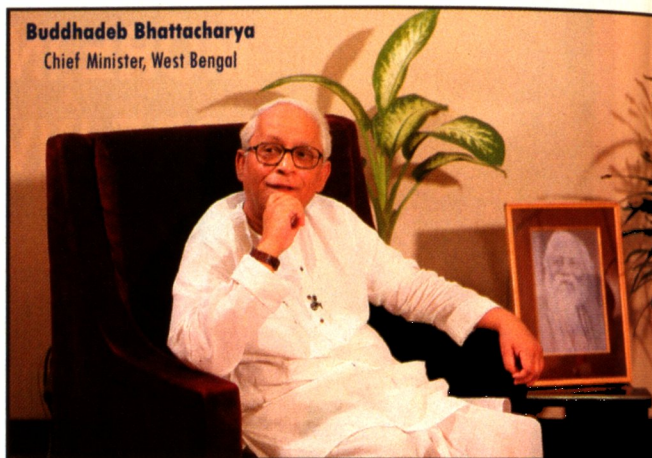
The core areas where it has made an impact are:

- Providing escort services and facilitation of investment proposals through single-window agency 'Shilpa Bandhu' or State Investment Facilitation Centre (SIFC).
- Promotion of joint sector ventures.
- Management and operation of the State Incentive Schemes as a nodal agency of the State Government.
- Promotion and development of industrial infrastructure and industry specific parks.

As far as its role as a financial guide is concerned, it works in the following ways:

- By providing term loans and short term loans to medium scale industries and assisted units.
- Equipment refinance scheme for existing profit making units.
- Bridge loan against admitted Incentive Schemes.
- Equity participation.
- Bill discounting facilities.

Buddhadeb Bhattacharya
Chief Minister, West Bengal



The WBIDC has facilitated some major industrial zones like the Apparel Park, Industrial Park for Iron & Steel, Biotech Park, Foundry Park, Rubber Park, Food Park and Knowledge City.

Interview of Nirupam Sen Minister – Industry



Industrialisation, development and rehabilitation are key words in West Bengal's plan of looking ahead to the future. Mr. Nirupam Sen, state Industry Minister, holds an optimistic view despite the recent upheavals in the national political scenario. There has been whispers in many corners that after the Left Front tried to pull the rug from under the UPA government in the Centre, the

Congress-led coalition will not take a lenient view of it and as an effect funds to West Bengal, for developmental projects, may not come by easily. Mr. Sen, however disagreed. "I don't expect any backlash from the centre. Ours is a democratic country and there has been situations where the government at the centre and that in the states have not been formed by the same political party. There can never be political discrimination based on that. If it happens, it will be very unfortunate."

How is the state making it easier for private entrepreneurs?

"Earlier, things were different. There was problems with licensing regime. But now things have changed. We are trying to make things a lot easier for those who want to start an industry here. And till now, the message has been positive."

How is the interest of the people of West Bengal also protected?

"Whenever we allow industrialisation and development, we also look into what is our priority, and that is employment for the local people. If a factory for automobiles is set up, then it also gives rise to auto component factories and that adds to the employment possibilities and also brings in more manufactures. If it is ship building, the ancillary industry also grows."

